



Facebook admits it makes you sad

Facebook admitted that it knows it's bad for your mental health, but they want you to keep using it anyway.
<http://dgit.in/SadFacebook>



Watchmen TV show

New Watchmen TV show from HBO gets a March filming date for its pilot episode.
<http://dgit.in/WtchmTV>

FEATURE

‘अमर-चित्र कथाएं’

Long Live Indian Comics

All about the Indian Comic book scene

Purusharth Sharma |
feedback@dgit.in

Comics and graphic novels are one of the most beautiful and engaging form of storytelling. Long before Spiderman, Batman and Superman came to India, we had our own homegrown superheroes. If you were born anytime before the 2000s, chances are the names Nagraj, Parmanu, Doga and the beloved Chacha Chaudhary are familiar to you. You probably grew up reading their stories and following their adventures.

HOW IT STARTED

1947-1965

It all began in the year 1947. Just around the time we gained independence, the first comic – *Chandamama* was released. Founded by noted Telugu movie producers of the time, B. Nagi Reddy and Aluri Chakrapani, the comic was initially published in Telugu only. It was aimed at teaching kids about the rich culture and history of our country and the vivid illustrations were inspired by mythological epics including *Mahabharata* and *Ramayana*.

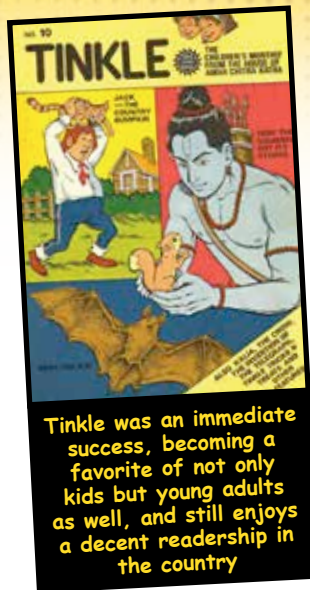
Almost 2 decades later, Times of India launched *Indrajal* comics. At that time, international comic houses had little to no visibility in India. Comics such as *Asterix and Obelix*, *Tintin* and *Archies* were available but were too expensive to become a phenomenon. *Indrajal* comics changed this by bringing international heroes, including

Phantom and Mandrake to India.

1965-1985

By 1970s the comic book scene in the country had been growing steadily, but the options were still limited. Either they were adaptations of international superheroes or mythological stories retelling the epics. This was to soon change. Pran Kumar Sharma was a young cartoonist working with a newspaper. He started a comic strip featuring a teenage boy named Daabu who went on adventures along with his mentor Professor Adhikari. This was soon followed by the epic *Chacha Chaudhary* and other famous comics of the time, and gave Pran the credit of making Indian comics a household name.

Around the same time, another famous series was born. India Book House, one of the leading publishing houses of the time, launched *Amar Chitra Katha*. It started off to a poor reception as the first ten issues were hindi translations of famous western classics such as *Snow White* and *Cinderella*. Realising that this wasn't working out with the Indian audience, Anant Pai, the editor of India Book House at the



Tinkle was an immediate success, becoming a favorite of not only kids but young adults as well, and still enjoys a decent readership in the country

time released *Krishna*, an illustrated retelling of the stories and adventures of Krishna. This was a huge success, and numerous other series spawned using the same formula making *Amar Chitra Katha* a household name.

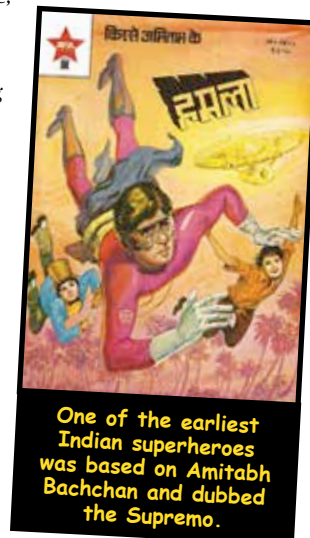
Following the success of *Amar Chitra Katha*, Indian Publishing House published the first Indian comic magazine called the *Tinkle*. It contained a wider range of content and the stories aimed to teach kids science,

moral values and history. The series still is immensely popular, and gave birth to a number of famous characters, including Supandi and Shikari Shambu.

1985- EARLY 2000 AGE OF THE INDIAN SUPERHEROES

By this time, comics in the western world mostly based on superheroes and had garnered a huge following, making Spiderman, Batman and Superman household names.

While back home we had only limited options in terms of superheroes to look up to. A couple of years ago the famous Diamond Comics had come out with India's first homegrown superhero comic dubbed the *Fauladi Singh*. The



One of the earliest Indian superheroes was based on Amitabh Bachchan and dubbed the Supremo.